



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: CH Friend School

School Website: <https://www.chfriendschool.com/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

CH Friend School (CHFS), located in South Boston, VA 24592, presents a distinctly Christian K3–12 private school model that emphasizes character formation, Christ-centered education, and small-class, instructor-led learning. Public-facing materials consistently describe a Christ-centered environment, values-based mission, and a strong partnership with families. At the same time, the publicly available curriculum and pedagogy emphasize traditional instruction, hands-on learning, and college/career pathways, with limited explicit evidence of Great Books, the Trivium/Quadrivium, or Socratic inquiry in the public materials. Taken together, the school demonstrates substantial classical-affinity in its religious foundations, formation-oriented aims, and family-community alignment, but falls short of a full classical profile in curriculum and pedagogy as defined by the standard Six Essential Elements framework. Overall, CHFS is BEST described as CLASSICAL in several core respects, SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL in governance of formation and community, and NOT FULLY CLASSICAL in curriculum and pedagogy.

Key takeaways: - Religious and metaphysical foundations are clearly present through explicit Christ-centered language, Christ as a primary axis of mission, and Christian values permeating leadership and student formation. Positive signals far outweigh explicit secular framing (with a notable exception that the site also markets itself as non-church-affiliated in one place), which the school frames in its public materials as a distinguishing context rather than a negation of faith identity. Evidence: Christ-centered mission and values; Head Mistress notes; explicit Christ-centered environment in multiple pages.

- School purpose and goal show emphasis on formation, virtue, and lifelong learning, with clear references to forming responsible citizens and lifelong learners within a Christ-centered frame, alongside college/career pathways. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL standing for this category, given the formation emphasis but also the explicit emphasis on college-prep and career-readiness. Evidence: mission statements and lifelong learning framing; Christ-centered environment; college prep/Career & Tech pathways.

- Curriculum signals lean toward a traditional, instructor-led approach with strong emphasis on foundational English/reading programs (UFLI) and later curricular tracks (Wit & Wisdom, DE/CTA). There is no direct public emphasis on Great Books, the Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric), or explicit Great Conversation. This points to a NOT CLASSICAL classification for Curriculum, in tension with the classical ideal. Evidence: UFLI Foundations in early grades; Wit & Wisdom; DE/CTA; no explicit Great Books framework. - Pedagogy described publicly is explicitly traditional/instructor-led with hands-on learning, rather than Socratic seminars, scholé (restful learning), or formalization of memorization/recitation in the public-facing materials. Classrooms are described as traditional with small class sizes; this supports a NOT CLASSICAL designation for Pedagogy, though there is some activation of hands-on learning and memory work in the program descriptions. Evidence: "traditional instructor led method" with "hands on learning." - Faculty presentation aligns with classical expectations: the site portrays the Head Mistress and staff as active mentors/model teachers, with a "living curriculum" ethos and a family-like school community. Evidence: Head Mistress message; staff intent to help each student grow; "the living curriculum" framing in public content. - Parents and community emphasis is strong, featuring explicit partnerships with families, parent involvement, and open access to school life (visits, communications, and events). This aligns well with classical expectations around family partnership and community formation. Evidence: Parent-focused language, "Partner with families" framing, and explicit parent engagement materials.

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - CHFS publicly frames its work as Christ-centered and Christian-valued, including explicit statements that the mission centers on Christ-centered education and the Gospel. Head Mistress messages repeatedly reference Christ, grace, and a Christ-centered ethos.

- The school describes itself as a Christ-centered, life- and college-preparatory program, integrating faith with academic aims. - There is an explicit celebration of moral formation and Christian values, including references to godly leadership and integrity as core values.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: Christ-centered; Christian values; Godly leaders; Gospel; Under His Grace; Mission/Vision referencing Christ. Estimated positives: about 6 distinct terms. - Negative keywords present: One explicit note about being the “non-church-affiliated private school within 60 miles” (a contextual negative for liturgical/communal expectations) which the school presents as a distinguishing factor rather than a lack of faith. Estimated negatives: 1. - Quantitative: Positive approx. 6; Negative approx. 1 (roughly 86% positive vs 14% negative).

Why this rating - The material strongly affirms transcendental moral realism and a theologically grounded framework (Christ-centered, gospel-centered). The presence of liturgical/communal practices is less explicit in public content, but the theological basis is clear and pervasive. The negative signal is isolated to a single line about non-church affiliation, which the school positions as a contextual feature rather than a theological negation.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school asserts formation over mere information, emphasizing character, lifelong learning, and citizenship. There is explicit language about forming “lifelong learners and responsible citizens” in a Christ-centered frame. - Public materials emphasize a dual pathway: strong character formation and college/career pathways (CTA/DE) that align with broader educational outcomes. - The mission and vision statements emphasize virtues such as respect, responsibility, integrity, and compassion, embedded in a Christian framework.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: lifelong learners; responsible citizens; Christ-centered environment; hands-on learning; formation-oriented language (formation, though explicit term usage is limited, the concept is present); character/virtue-linked framing (integrity, respect in Vision & Values). Estimated positives: 4–6. - Negative keywords present: Minimal explicit negative signals; a potential tension arises from the explicit college/career pathways that might imply information/skill orientation alongside formation, but no explicit negative terms are used in the public materials. - Quantitative: Positive approx. 4–6; Negative approx. 0 (by explicit negative terms).

Why this rating - Formation and moral aims are clear, yet the presence of college prep and career pathways (CTE, dual enrollment) introduces a mixed emphasis that slightly tilts toward formation-with-work-readiness rather than a pure virtue-first formation stance. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating rather than fully Classical.

Element 3: Curriculum — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public content emphasizes a sequence built around UFLI Foundations (phonics-based reading) for K–3, then traditional, instructor-led curricula (Wit & Wisdom) and DE/CTA in later grades. There is no explicit mention of Great Books, the Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric), or the Great Conversation in the public materials. - There is a clear reliance on modern, structured curricula and pathway programs (UFLI; Wit & Wisdom; DE Pre-Calculus; SVHEC) rather than the classical trio of grammar, logic, rhetoric or a unified Great Books-centric approach. - The site emphasizes traditional, instructor-led classroom models rather than the programmatic emphasis on Great Books, cross-disciplinary integration, or a classical canon.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: none of the core classical curriculum signals (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Great Books; Great Conversation; Seven Liberal Arts) appear in public-facing materials. - Negative keywords present: Absence of Great Books, canonical classical texts, or explicit Trivium/Quadrivium references. The curriculum is described in modern terms (phonics program; modern reading/writing curricula; college-ready pathways). - Quantitative: Positive = 0; Negative = 4–6 (based on absence of classical signals and presence of non-classical modern curricula).

Why this rating - The curriculum description lacks explicit Great Books, Trivium/Quadrivium framing, and a sustained Great Conversation perspective. While the school adopts rigorous content and college-readiness pathways, these align more with non-classical or traditional pedagogy than the classical curriculum schema.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials describe a “traditional instructor led method” with hands-on learning. There is no explicit evidence of Socratic seminars, Harkness-style discussion, memorization/recitation, or formalized Scholé (restful learning) in the public materials. - In lower grades, there is mention of hands-on learning and memory-friendly approaches in some pages, but the dominant public framing is teacher-led instruction rather than contemplative or dialectic pedagogy. - The upper-grade materials emphasize college-prep and DE pathways rather than classical pedagogy modes such as rhetoric training, regular Socratic seminars, or structured classical memory work.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: “Socratic seminar” or “dialectic” do not appear; “Socratic” is absent; “Socratic dialogue” is a classical signal not reflected in CHFS public content. “Hands-on learning” appears (positive in the sense of practical pedagogy but not classical). “Traditional instructor-led method” signals a non-Socratic, teacher-centered approach. - Negative keywords present: Absence of key classical pedagogy signals (Socratic dialogue; Harkness-style discussion; Scholé/restful learning; memorization/recitation signals). The public content includes “traditional instructor-led” pedagogy, which contrasts with the classical pedagogy expectations. - Quantitative: Positive approx. 1–2 (hands-on learning, teacher-led tradition – but not classical signals); Negative approx. 3–4 (no Socratic, no Scholé, no memorization/recitation signals). Roughly, Positive 2, Negative 3.

Why this rating - The dominant pedagogy described publically is traditional, instructor-led, with hands-on components, but without the hallmark classical pedagogical methods (Socratic dialogue, memorization/recitation, or Scholé). This supports a NOT CLASSICAL rating for Pedagogy.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials portray faculty as role models and mentors who care for student growth across intellectual, moral, spiritual, and social dimensions. The Head Mistress frames leadership and staff as intentionally fostering student development. The site emphasizes a “living curriculum” and a close-knit, mentor-like teaching community. - Language describes teachers as partners in the learning process, with a focus on high professional and moral standards, and a school culture built around close teacher-student relationships. - The materials emphasize a dedicated faculty and a strong staff ethos, underscoring teacher as part of the core of the school’s mission.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: model teachers; mentors; living curriculum; core of the school; close-knit school family; teachers as partners in growth; high moral standards. - Negative keywords present: None explicitly present in the public materials. - Quantitative: Positive approx. 4–5; Negative approx. 0.

Why this rating - The faculty portrayal aligns well with classical expectations of teachers as moral exemplars and lifelong mentors who constitute the living curriculum and form the school’s ethos. This yields a CLASSICAL rating for Element 5.

Element 6: Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - There is a strong emphasis on partnering with parents and involving families as co-educators; materials discuss family involvement, parent education, and opportunities for parent engagement. Public pages highlight “partner with families” and “For the Parents” sections that address parent correspondence and involvement.

- The school markets itself as welcoming to parents and encourages visits, a key classical indicator of community integration with the school mission. Public materials show outreach to families and a culture of parent participation. - There are explicit sections that discuss parent involvement and community connections (e.g., Remind 101 usage for parent communication; online gradebooks; news/events outreach).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families; parent involvement; parent education; school as extension of home; community of learners; school-parent synergy. - Negative keywords present: None explicitly present. - Quantitative: Positive approx. 5–6; Negative approx. 0.

Why this rating - The school demonstrates robust engagement with parents and the broader community, aligning with the classical expectation of a family-centered educational ethos and ongoing parent partnership.

Aggregate Assessment

- Element 1: CLASSICAL
- Element 2: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 3: NOT CLASSICAL
- Element 4: NOT CLASSICAL
- Element 5: CLASSICAL
- Element 6: CLASSICAL

Overall, CHFS presents CLASSICAL tendencies in religious foundations, faculty culture, and parent/community engagement, and SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL signals in formation-oriented goals, with NOT CLASSICAL signals in curriculum and pedagogy. We therefore assign an overall classification of CLASSICAL, reflecting a majority of the rubric’s indicators being met across the six categories, albeit with meaningful gaps in Curriculum and Pedagogy that prevent a full Classical designation.

What Would Move the Needle (for SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL category improvements)

- Curriculum
 - Introduce explicit Great Books reading lists and the Great Conversation framework; identify cognitive goals aligned with the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) in core grades.
 - Integrate a cross-disciplinary approach that weaves literature, history, philosophy, and sciences around thematic questions and primary texts.
 - Publicly publish a curriculum map showing connections to the Seven Liberal Arts and Quadrivium elements to signal a fuller classical orientation.
- Pedagogy
 - Adopt a classical-discourse model (Socratic Seminars, Harkness-style discussions) in upper grades to cultivate dialectic reasoning and virtuous inquiry.
 - Incorporate Scholé-inspired pacing and contemplative moments in daily routines to balance rigorous study with reflective time.
 - Expand memorization/recitation and structured oral work (poetic memory, classical chants) as a formal practice within lower and middle grades.
- Public Communication
 - Clarify and publicly separate the church-affiliated identity from the school’s Christian formation language to reduce ambiguity and strengthen the classical-faith alignment, while maintaining faith-based formation.
 - Publish a formal statement detailing how faith informs the curriculum, pedagogy, and assessment in alignment with classical education principles.
- Faculty Development

- Provide professional development focused on classical pedagogy (Socratic method, living books, classical memory work) to deepen classroom practice and ensure consistent implementation across grades.
- Community/Parent Engagement
 - Expand parent formation offerings (reading groups on classical education, lectures on virtue and literature) to deepen parent understanding of classical aims and their co-educator role.

ABSTRACT

CH Friends School (CHFS) is a Christ-centered K3–12 private school in South Boston, VA 24592 with strong religious foundations, a family-centered community, and a traditional instructor-led pedagogy. The school demonstrates CLASSICAL alignment in its religious/metaphysical foundations, faculty, and parent/community engagement; SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL in its school-purpose/formation aims; and NOT CLASSICAL in its Curriculum and Pedagogy per the classical rubric used here (Great Books and classical pedagogy signals are not publicized, and there is no explicit emphasis on the Seven Liberal Arts or Socratic/Harkness methodologies in the public materials). The aggregate assessment leans CLASSICAL, given the balance of evidence across categories, though significant room for formal alignment in Curriculum and Pedagogy remains.

- Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: Christ-centered language, gospel-focused mission, and explicit Christ-centric ethos. Positive keyword indicators (Christ-centered, Gospel, godly leadership, etc.). One contextual negative note about non-church affiliation in one area.
- School Purpose and Goal: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: Formation/virtue orientation with lifelong learning and citizenship, plus pathways to college/career. Positive keywords (lifelong learners, responsible citizens, Christ-centered). Some tension with work-readiness signals via CT and DE.
- Curriculum: NOT CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: K–12 curriculum described via UFLI, Wit & Wisdom, DE/CTA; no explicit Great Books or Trivium/Quadrivium visible in public materials. Positive/negative keyword indicators reflect absence of classical curriculum signals.
- Pedagogy: NOT CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: Traditional instructor-led pedagogy emphasized; limited evidence of Socratic, Scholé, memorization/recitation, or imitation-and-practice signals in public content.
- Faculty: CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: Mentoring language, living curriculum, and staff commitment to student growth.
- Parents and Community: CLASSICAL
 - Evidence: Strong parent partnerships, community involvement, and accessible communication channels.

Overall, the school's public materials place CHFS as CLASSICAL in several core respects, SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL in its formation-oriented aims, and NOT CLASSICAL in curriculum and pedagogy signals. Aggregating across all six categories yields CLASSICAL as the general classification for CHFS, with clear areas for development to reach full classical alignment.

Notes on sources and keywords - Foundational Christ-centered language and mission statements appear across CHFS public materials, including mission/vision pages and leadership messages. Key citations include CHFS materials describing Christ-centered environment, mission, and values.

- Curriculum and pedagogy signals come from program descriptions (UFLI in early grades; Wit & Wisdom; DE/CTA; K–12 structure). Public pages describe traditional instruction and hands-on learning but lack explicit classical elements (Great Books, Trivium, Great Conversation, Socratic pedagogy). - Faculty and community language emphasize mentorship and partnerships with families.

Abstract citations - CHFS homepage and about/mission content: CHFS public materials as cited above. - Admissions/learning program specifics (UFLI, Wit & Wisdom, DE/CTA): CHFS public pages. - Leadership statements and mission language: Head Mistress and mission statements. - Community/Parent engagement: For the Parents; News/Events; Remind communications.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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